

Say it early.

TEACHER TO COORDINATOR

The ask, in five moves

1 Could we schedule 20 minutes to talk about my workload?

Ask for a meeting. Do not start in the corridor.

2 Here is what I'm seeing: I'm regularly working beyond my contracted hours, mostly on marking and planning.

One fact first, feeling second.

3 It's starting to affect my planning and my energy in class.

Say the effect on the students, not only on you.

4 What I'd like to propose is fewer extra duties until the end of term.

One request, small enough to say yes to.

5 Could we check in again on the 15th?

A date turns a complaint into a plan.

TOO BLUNT, SAY THIS

Say the better version out loud first

~~I can't take this anymore.~~

→ **I'm at my limit with the current workload. Could we look at options?**

~~You give us too much work.~~

→ **Could we review my workload and see what can come off my plate?**

~~Nobody listens to teachers here.~~

→ **Could I share some feedback from the classroom?**

~~I'm thinking of quitting.~~

→ **I want to be open with you: I'm not sure this role is sustainable for me. What could change?**

~~That class is out of control.~~

→ **Behaviour is taking a lot of class time. Could we agree on a plan and some support?**

Could we... / I'd like to...

Not "I want" or "you must". It keeps the door open.

Fact first, feeling second.

"I'm working beyond my hours" before "I'm exhausted".

Parents = pais.

Relatives = parentes. The false friend that escapes everyone.

Feedback has no plural.

Some feedback, a piece of feedback. Never "feedbacks".

Name the problem. Give one fact. Ask for one change, with a date.

WHEN THE ANSWER IS NOT YET YES

The answer

1 "I understand there is no budget for that. **Is there something smaller** we could try?"

2 "**Could we revisit this** after the mid-year break?"

3 "**What would you need to see from me** to make that possible?"

4 When there is another offer: "**That helps, but it doesn't solve** the hours. Could we do both?"

5 "**Let me think about it** and get back to you by Friday."

TEACHER TO PARENT

Hard news, in three moves

1 Say what you saw. "I've noticed that Pedro hasn't handed in his homework for three weeks."

2 Ask what they see. "**Does that match what you see at home?**"

3 Agree a next step, with a date. "**Could we try** a homework planner and talk again in two weeks?"

Describe the behaviour, not the child. "He hasn't handed in homework" is something you saw. "He is lazy" is a judgement.

A REAL EXCHANGE

Coordinator and teacher

C Is this about the extra classes, or something bigger?

T Both. I'm happy to cover them, but I'm regularly working beyond my hours. **Could we look at** what can come off my plate?

C Isn't everyone busy right now?

T I hear you. **That's why I'm raising it early**, before it affects my classes. Could we check in on the 15th?

Satisfied, not valued.

THE OTHER SIDE OF THE TABLE

Brazil and the OECD average · TALIS 2024

Satisfied with the job



Class time spent keeping order



Believe teachers are valued in society



Say the work is very stressful



All figures in %. OECD, TALIS 2024 (released 6 Oct 2025), as reported by Agência Brasil.

NUMBERS YOU CAN QUOTE

With the source

44 million more teachers are needed worldwide by 2030. **58%** of them would replace teachers who leave.

UNESCO, Global Report on Teachers, 2024

Attrition among primary teachers **almost doubled**: 4.6% in 2015, 9% in 2022.

UNESCO, 2024

In half of all countries, primary teachers are paid **less than other professions** that need similar qualifications.

UNESCO, 2024

USA, 2025: **53%** of teachers report burnout. They work **49 hours** a week, 10 more than contracted.

RAND, State of the American Teacher Survey

HOW HR SAYS IT

Five terms and the sentence for the meeting

TERM	IN THE MEETING
turnover <i>n.</i>	"What is our turnover this year, and who is leaving?"
attrition <i>n.</i>	"Global attrition among primary teachers almost doubled between 2015 and 2022."
retain <i>v.</i> retention <i>n.</i>	"How do we retain our best teachers?" "Retention is a pay question and a workload question."
workload <i>n.</i>	"The current workload is not sustainable."
backfill <i>v.</i>	"We need to backfill two positions before March."
onboarding <i>n.</i>	"Onboarding should include a mentor in the first year."

A TOOL FOR HR · SHRM

The five stay interview questions

- 1 What do you look forward to each day when you commute to work?
- 2 What are you learning here, and what do you want to learn?
- 3 Why do you stay here?
- 4 When is the last time you thought about leaving us, and what prompted it?
- 5 What can I do to make your job better for you?

Richard Finnegan, SHRM. Ask every employee the same five questions, and listen 80% of the time. A **stay interview** asks people who are still here. An **exit interview** asks people who are leaving.

A teacher can like the job and still leave. HR looks at workload, pay and respect, not only at satisfaction.

STAFF ROOM TALK

Can you say it to your coordinator?

CHUNK	AT WORK
I'm swamped.	👍 Fine. Add the plan: "I'm swamped this week, so I'm prioritising marking."
I'm stretched thin.	👍 Fine. "I'm stretched thin across too many classes."
I'm burnt out.	👍 Serious word. Say it with a request: "I'm close to burnout. Could we talk?"
I take work home every night.	👍 Fine. It is a fact, not a complaint.
I'm fried.	👎 Friends only. "I'm running low on energy."
It's a zoo in there.	👎 Friends only. "That group is very hard to manage right now."
They walk all over me.	👎 Too much. "I'm struggling to set limits with this group."
I'm done. I'm out.	👎 An ultimatum. "I need to talk about whether this role is sustainable."
I'm quiet quitting.	👎 Sounds like a threat. "I'm setting clearer limits on my hours."

WATCH OUT · FALSE FRIENDS

The word looks Portuguese. It is not.

LOOKS LIKE	WRONG → RIGHT
parentes	I met his relatives about his grades. → I met his parents .
atrito	There is attrition between the teachers. → There is friction . (Attrition = people leaving over time.)
colégio	I teach at a college. → I teach at a school . (College = faculdade.)
suportar	I can't support this workload. → I can't cope with this workload.
pretender	I pretend to ask for a change. → I plan to ask for a change.
aposentar	He retired his request. → He withdrew his request. (Retire = aposentar-se.)